CHAPTER 6 · DEEP DIVE · HOUSE & DIVIDED

The Lincoln–Douglas Debates

Seven Illinois towns, seven hours of argument, and two visions of America's future. 1858.

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

Seven Illinois towns, seven hours of argument, and two visions of America's future. 1858.

If both men said they opposed Black equality in many ways, what exactly were they arguing about — and why did it matter so much?

A Senate Race Watched by the Nation

1858

It was only a race for an Illinois Senate seat, but the whole country watched. The incumbent, Democrat Stephen Douglas — author of the Kansas–Nebraska Act — faced a tall, relatively unknown Republican lawyer, Abraham Lincoln.

Across seven towns, the two men debated for hours before enormous crowds. There were no microphones — just two men, their arguments, and a nation trying to decide what it believed.

Abraham Lincoln — photograph, 1858, public domain (Library of Congress).

Abraham Lincoln, 1858

THE CHALLENGER

A one-term congressman and prairie lawyer, written off by many — until these debates made him famous.

Abraham Lincoln — photograph, 1858, public domain (Library of Congress).

Stephen A. Douglas

THE INCUMBENT

"The Little Giant" — the most powerful Democrat in the Senate and the architect of popular sovereignty.

Stephen A. Douglas — photograph, public domain (Library of Congress).

Is Slavery Wrong?

THE REAL DISAGREEMENT

Both men, by the standards of their time, held racist views and both denied supporting full social equality. So what divided them? One question: is slavery a moral wrong?

Douglas said he “did not care” whether a territory voted slavery up or down — let the people decide. Lincoln said slavery was a moral wrong that must not be allowed to spread. That gap — not caring versus calling it wrong — was the whole argument.

Stephen A. Douglas — photograph, public domain (Library of Congress).

STEPHEN DOUGLAS · 1858

I believe this Government was made on the white basis … made by white men, for the benefit of white men and their posterity forever.

ABRAHAM LINCOLN · 1858

In the right to eat the bread, without the leave of anybody else, which his own hand earns, he is my equal and the equal of Judge Douglas, and the equal of every living man.

He Lost the Seat — and Won the Country

THE OUTCOME

Douglas kept his Senate seat. But the debates were printed in newspapers nationwide, and Lincoln's clear moral case against the spread of slavery made him a national figure almost overnight.

Two years later, those same two men would face each other again — this time for the presidency. The seven Illinois debates were the rehearsal for 1860.

Abraham Lincoln — photograph, 1858, public domain (Library of Congress).

Weigh the Arguments

YOUR TURN

You'll put Lincoln's and Douglas's own words side by side and practice argumentation — identifying each man's claim, and deciding which better answered the question the country faced.